What It Means When a Man Falls From the Sky

By Lesley Arimah Nneka

NARRATOR: What does it mean when a man falls from the sky? **(Pg 151-174)** It means twenty-four-hour news coverage. It means politicians doing damage control; activists egging on protests. It means Francisco Furcal's granddaughter at a press conference defending her family legacy.

GRANDDAUGHTER: *(into a microphone)* My grandfather's formula is sound. Math is constant and absolute. Any problems are the fault of those who miscalculate it.

INTRODUCTION

Welcome to the future – a world ravaged by climate change and geopolitical conflict. As its inhabitants lament the plight (or the intrusion) of refugees fleeing turmoil, many take solace in a discovery that is said to have the ability to ease all human pain. Furcal's Forumla has been discovered and the Mathematicians, though there are few, can calculate a person's emotional agony and then undo it. A world without pain . . . a world without suffering? It sounds like Heaven.

But. . . some Mathematicians have pushed past their limits with grievous results and are using the Furcal Formula to manipulate the physical world.

What it Means When a Man Falls from the Sky by Lesley Arimah Nneka

4NG Fanatics

NARRATOR: 2,400 Mathematicians worked the globe and made their living calculating and subtracting emotions, drawing them from living bodies like poison from a wound.

Nneoma was one of 57 registered Mathematicians who specialized in calculating grief, down from 59 last year. Alvin Claspell had committed suicide after, if the stories were to be believed, going mad and trying to eat himself. And Kioni Mutahi has simply disappeared.

This work wasn't for everyone. It wasn't a profession you chose or aspired to; you could either do it or you couldn't.

For Nneoma, it started when she was fourteen, in math class. The teacher had showed them a long string of Furcal's Formula, purchased from the Center like a strain of a virus. To most of the other students, it was an impenetrable series of numbers and symbols, but to

Nneoma it was as simple as the alphabet. From then on she could see a person's sadness as plainly as the clothes he wore. And now, she'd been doing it for so long she could exorcise the deepest of traumas for even the most resistant of patients.

A message dinged on the phone console -- her assistant reminding her of the lecture she was to give at the school. She gathered her papers and rang the car, which pulled up to the glass doors almost immediately. They drove through the wide streets and passed a playground full of sweaty egg-white children. It wasn't that Nneoma had a problem with the Britons per se, but some of her father had rubbed off on her. At his harshest Father would call them refugees rather than allies

FATHER: They come here with no country of their own and try to take over everything and don't contribute anything.

NARRATOR: That wasn't entirely true. When the floods started swallowing the British Isles, they'd reached out to Biafra, a plea for help that was answered. Terms

4NG Fanatics

were drawn, equitable exchanges of services contracted. But while one hand reached out for help, the other wielded a knife. Once here, the Britons had insisted on their own lands and their own separate government. A compromise, aided by the British threat to deploy biological weapons, resulted in the Biafra-Britannia Alliance. Shared lands, shared governments, shared grievances. Better a mutually beneficial, if unwanted, alliance than what the Americans had done in Mexico.

When things began to fall apart, the world cracked open by earthquakes and long dormant volcanoes stretched, yawned and bellowed, the churches (mosques, temples) fell, not just the physical buildings shaken to dust by tremors, but the institutions as well. Into the vacuum stepped Francisco Furcal, a Chilean Mathematician who discovered a formula that explained the universe. It, like the universe, was infinite and the idea that the formula had no end and, perhaps, by extension, humanity had no end, was exactly what the world had needed.

Over decades, people began to experiment with this infinite formula, and in the process discovered equations that coincided with the anatomy of the human body, making work like hers possible. Then the rumors started that Furcal's Formula was wrong. They were just that, rumors, but then a man fell from the sky.

As they neared the school, they could see a few protesters with gleaming electronic placards. The angry red of angry men. Nneoma greeted the class -- filled with bored faces, most around thirteen or fourteen with few caring or understanding what she did, too untouched by tragedy to understand her necessity. But schools like these, which gathered the best and brightest several nations had to offer, paid the Center handsomely to have people like her speak and it was the easiest money she earned.

NNEOMA: How many of you can look at someone and know that they are sad?

NARRATOR: The whole class raised their hands.

NNEOMA: How many of you can look at a person who is sad, know why they are sad and fix it?

4NG Fanatics

NARRATOR: All hands lowered. She had their attention now…

NNEOMA: Some Mathematicians remove pain, some deal in negative emotions, but we all fix the equation of a person. The bravest (she winked) have tried their head at using the Formula to make the human body defy gravity, for physical endeavors, like flight.

B**OY:** What you are doing is wrong. My dad says that you shouldn't be stopping a person from feeling natural hardships. That's what it means to be human.

NARRATOR: She studied the boy and noted on his wrist his father's occupation (lawyer), his class (first). People who'd lived easy lives, who'd had moderate but manageable difficulties then dared to compare their meager hardship with unfathomable woes.

NNEOMA: Your father and those people protesting outside have no concept of what real pain is. Their feelings on this matter are invalid. I would never ask a person who hasn't tasted a dish whether it needs more salt.

GIRL: *(raises hand)*

NNEOMA: *(thinking) Not her, not her!*

NARRATOR: She'd been trying to ignore the girl since she walked into the classroom. She didn't need to look at her wrist to know that the girl was Senegalese and had been affected by the Elimination. It was etched all over her, this sorrow.

GIRL: *(with obvious pain in her voice)* So you can make it go away?

NNEOMA: Yes, I can. But it is a highly regulated and very expensive process. Most of my clients are heavily subsidized by their governments, but even then. You have to be a citizen.

NARRATOR: The girl lowered her eyes to her lap, fighting tears. The Elimination began after the French had won the trust of their Sengali hosts. The Senegalese newspapers that issued warnings were dismissed as conspiracy rags, rabble-rousers inventing trouble. But then the camps, the raids, and the mysterious illness that wiped out millions. Then the cabinet members murdered in their beds. The girl must have lived through the unthinkable. The weight of her mourning was too much, and Nneoma left the room. She saw the sign for the ladies room and stepped inside.

4NG Fanatics

NNEOMA: *(checking the stalls to make sure she is alone, she bends forward taking deep breaths)*

NARRATOR: The bathroom door creaked open. Nneoma knew who it was. The girl couldn't help but to seek her out. Nneoma held out her arms and the girl walked into them. And Nneoma saw the sadness. The girl's mother shredded by gunfire. Her brother taken in the night by a gang of thugs. Her father falling to the synthesized virus that attacked all the melanin in his skin till his body was an open sore. Hunger so deep she'd swallowed fistfuls of mud. *(Beat)*

Nneoma worked almost exclusively with parents who'd lost a child, wealthy couples who'd thought death couldn't touch them, till it did. When the Center partnered with governments to work with their distressed populations, it was Kioni Mutahi who worked with those people full time. Until she disappeared.

NNEOMA: *(holding the girl in her arms she absorbs all the pain and suffering, she begins sobbing)*

NARRATOR: No one had really been able to explain why one person could take another person's grief.

Mathematical theories abounded based on how humans were, in the plainest sense, a bulk of atoms held together by positives and negatives, an equation all their own, a type of cellular math. A theologian might call it a miracle, a kiss of grace from God's own mouth. But in that room, it simply meant that a girl had an unbearable burden and then she did not. *(Beat)*

The ride back home was silent. As she cleared the corner around her compound, she saw a small crowd gathered at her gate. *Protesters?* she wondered in shock before she registered the familiar faces of her neighbors.

MAN: We called medical right away. She was banging on your gate and screaming.

NARRATOR: The woman wore no shoes and her toes were wounds. How on earth had she been able to bypass city security?

NNEOMA: *(recognizing her colleague)* Kioni?

KIONI: *(frantically she looks about her in fear)* Nneoma we have to go, we have to go now.

NARRATOR: Every bare inch of her skin was scratched or bitten or cut in some way. Her usually neat dreadlocks

4NG Fanatics

were half missing, her scalp raw and puckered like someone had yanked them out. The smell . . .

NNEOMA: Who did this to you?

NARRATOR: And then she remembered Alvin Claspell and the stories of him trying to eat himself.

KIONI: *(sobbing)* They just come, and they come and they come.

NARRATOR: How many people had Kioni worked with over the last decade, five thousand? Ten? Ten thousand traumas in her psyche, squeezing past each other, vying for the attention. What would happen if you couldn't forget, if every emotion from every person whose grief you'd eaten came back? It could happen if something went wrong with the formula millions and millions of permutations down the line. A thousand falling men landing on you. . . The breadth of it was so vast, ***too*** vast.

SOURCE INFORMATION

Author: Lesley Arimah Nneka
ISBN: 978-0735211025
Publisher: Riverhead Books
Date (Month/Year): April 2017